

Measuring the Flexibility Gap

Employer and Employee Valuations of
Flexible Work Arrangements in Singapore

SMU–SNEF FWA Study

Study Overview

Research questions

1. How are FWAs currently accessed and used?
2. Which arrangements do employees and employers value, and by how much?
3. What support could help increase effective FWA use?

Employee survey

1,020
respondents

Employer survey

303
respondents

Parallel online surveys of employees and employers, each with a discrete choice experiment (DCE). Current-employment descriptives use 1,004 employee respondents. Employee and employer samples are separate and unmatched.

FWA Landscape

Upload the PNG figure
PNG figure placeholder

Remote work is the most common FWA; employee-reported use remains below availability.

Policies and Pathways

Employees

How current FWA was established



Employers

Formal written FWA policy

66.0%

have a formal written
FWA policy



Yes 66%

No 34%

Company-wide policies are the largest single route, alongside individual and informal arrangements.

Employee base: N=869; employed respondents selecting neither “None” nor “Don’t know” in the original availability question.
Employer base: N=303. Samples are separate and unmatched.

TG-FWAR Awareness

Upload the PNG figure
PNG figure placeholder

About half of each sample report familiarity; employees are more likely to be unaware.

Bases: currently employed employees, N=1,004; employers, N=303. Familiarity is self-reported. Samples are separate and unmatched.

Requests and Outcomes

Formal FWA requests since TG-FWAR took effect

Employees

Upload the PNG figure
PNG figure placeholder

Employers

Upload the PNG figure
PNG figure placeholder

Among employees who had heard of TG-FWAR, 65.7% applied; 64.0% of applicants reported full approval.

Request questions were shown only to respondents who had heard of TG-FWAR (employees also had to be currently employed). Request bases: employees N=832; employers N=280. Outcome bases: applicants N=547; receiving employers N=154. Employee outcomes concern individual requests; employer outcomes concern within-firm approval shares (all or most=60–100%; some or about half=10–59%; few or none=0–9%). Samples are separate and unmatched.

The Choice Experiment

An example choice

Example DCE choice task
PNG figure placeholder

How it works

- Two job profiles per task
- Six tasks per respondent
- Arrangements and salary vary across profiles
- Parallel employee and employer versions

Choices reveal trade-offs between salary and work arrangements, so each arrangement can be valued in salary terms (WTP).

Employee Preferences

Employee FWA WTP estimates and 95% confidence intervals
PNG figure placeholder

Among FWAs, fully remote work has the largest estimated employee salary-equivalent value.

Conditional logit; N=1,020; respondent-clustered SEs, 95% CIs. Negative values indicate salary employees would forgo.

SMU-SNEF FWA Study

Employer Preferences

Employer FWA WTP estimates and 95% confidence intervals

PNG figure placeholder

Employers require the largest estimated salary offset for fully remote work.

Conditional logit; N=303; respondent-clustered SEs, 95% CIs. Negative values indicate salary reductions required by employers. Bases: onsite, fixed hours, full-time, low turnover and collaborative culture. These are hypothetical trade-offs, not wage recommendations

Valuation Gaps

Employee–employer salary-adjustment gaps and 95% CIs
PNG figure placeholder

Fully remote work and part-time work show the largest FWA valuation gaps in point estimates.

Gap = employee minus employer salary adjustment; N=1,020 and 303, respectively. Positive gaps indicate larger employer-SMU–SNEF FWA Study

Employee Heterogeneity

Gender and work location

Male / Female

1–2 days WFH

3–4 days WFH

Fully remote

WTP estimates and 95% CIs

PNG figure placeholder

Age and work schedules

19–39 / 40+

Staggered hours

Compressed 4-day week

WTP estimates and 95% CIs

PNG figure placeholder

Point estimates suggest women value remote work more; work-schedule valuations also differ by age.

Conditional-logit subgroup estimates with 95% CIs. Men N=593; women N=424 (three respondents outside the male/female coding excluded). Ages 19–39 N=546; 40+ N=474. Point-estimate contrasts do not establish statistical differences.

Constraints and Concerns

Employer WFH valuations, by subgroup

Physical-presence requirements

Employer WFH valuations by
physical-presence requirements
PNG figure placeholder

Reported concerns

Employer WFH valuations by concern score
PNG figure placeholder

Greater physical-presence needs and higher concerns are associated with larger required WFH salary offsets.

Conditional logit. Most roles require presence: N=98; some/few: N=205. Concern score: mean of productivity, coordination and creativity concerns; low (≤ 3) N=93, high (> 3) N=210. Associations are not causal.

Current Practice and Preferences

Employees

Current users / Non-users

Compressed workweek and part-time
WTP by current arrangement
PNG figure placeholder

Employers

Any current WFH / No current WFH

Remote-work WTP by current WFH practice
PNG figure placeholder

Current arrangements are associated with preferences, but experience and selection cannot be separated here.

Employee current-use interaction model: N=1,004 currently employed respondents; each arrangement compared with its non-users. Employer subgroup models: any current WFH N=243; none N=60. Current practice is self-reported.

Key Findings

Access and use

- 66.0% of employers have a formal written FWA policy
- Familiar with TG-FWAR: 55.1% of employees; 52.8% of employers
- 64.0% of employee applicants report full approval

Employee side

- Fully remote work has the largest FWA value in point estimates
- Point estimates vary by gender (remote work) and age (schedules)

Employer side

- Largest FWA gaps: fully remote and part-time work
- WFH valuations vary with physical-presence requirements and reported concerns

Support should address both understanding of the request process and practical implementation.

Supporting FWA Adoption

Potential responses to test, informed by the survey patterns

Evidence / question	Support to consider	What to test
Incomplete familiarity with TG-FWAR	Clear guidance and worked examples	Understanding and request behaviour
Operational requirements and reported concerns	Task-specific options and HR / manager support	Feasibility, coordination and performance
Preferences vary with current practice	Time-limited, evaluated pilots	Learning, take-up and sustained use

These are candidate interventions. The survey does not establish whether preference differences are caused by misinformation, experience or operational constraints.

Appendix

Additional results, methods and supporting evidence

Employee Sample

Employee sample characteristics
PNG figure placeholder

Employer Sample

Employer sample characteristics
PNG figure placeholder

Question Routing

Question eligibility and denominators
PNG figure placeholder

Availability Adjustments

Original versus adjusted availability and provision
PNG figure placeholder

Approval Categories

Original employer approval categories
PNG figure placeholder

Future FWA Plans

Plans to expand, maintain or reduce FWAs
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Gender

Full gender results
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Age

Full age results
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Any Caregiving

No caregiving / Any caregiving
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Role

Employee role-level results
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Education

Education-group results
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Availability

WTP by corresponding FWA availability
PNG figure placeholder

Employee WTP: Current Use

Full current-arrangement results
PNG figure placeholder

Employer WTP: Firm Size

Organisation-size results
PNG figure placeholder

Employer WTP: Respondent Role

Respondent-role results
PNG figure placeholder

Industry: Work Location

Industry-specific location preferences
PNG figure placeholder

Industry: Work Schedule

Industry-specific schedule preferences
PNG figure placeholder

Industry: Workload

Industry-specific workload preferences
PNG figure placeholder

Industry: Turnover

Industry-specific turnover preferences
PNG figure placeholder

Industry: Work Culture

Industry-specific work-culture preferences
PNG figure placeholder

Productivity Concerns

Employer productivity concerns
PNG figure placeholder

Coordination Concerns

Employer coordination concerns
PNG figure placeholder

Creativity Concerns

Employer creativity and innovation concerns
PNG figure placeholder

Technological Readiness

Employer technological readiness
PNG figure placeholder

Salary-Reduction Beliefs

Employer salary-reduction beliefs
PNG figure placeholder

DCE Design

Attributes, levels and reference categories
PNG figure placeholder

WTP Interpretation

WTP calculation and sign conventions
PNG figure placeholder

Conditional Logit Estimates

Coefficients and standard errors
PNG figure placeholder

Response Patterns

Choice-position and same-side response patterns
PNG figure placeholder

Response-Quality Checks

Estimates excluding same-side respondents
PNG figure placeholder

Salary Sensitivity

Salary-trimming robustness
PNG figure placeholder

Choices and Relative Salary

Choice patterns under the specified attribute-ordering assumptions
PNG figure placeholder

Stated and Observed Trade-offs

DCE WTP and adjusted observed salary differentials
PNG figure placeholder

Related literature